

IXIGO PRODUCT CAPSTONE

Confident Alternatives

Helping travellers resolve an unavailable booking with speed and honesty

26% → 42%

resolved-booking target

Why, What, How, and What Next

01

Why

The problem — why 74% of unavailable bookings never resolve today

02

What

The research — who we talked to, and what we actually learned

03

How

The solution — two features, prioritized, prototyped, and designed with honesty built in

04

What Next

The plan — how it launches, scales, is measured, and what could still go wrong

A Platform at Real Scale

ixigo's train business is large enough that even a small improvement in resolution rate moves real revenue.

84.82M

Monthly Active Users (Q4 FY26)

104.12M

Train passenger segments booked, FY26

₹511 cr

FY26 train revenue from operations

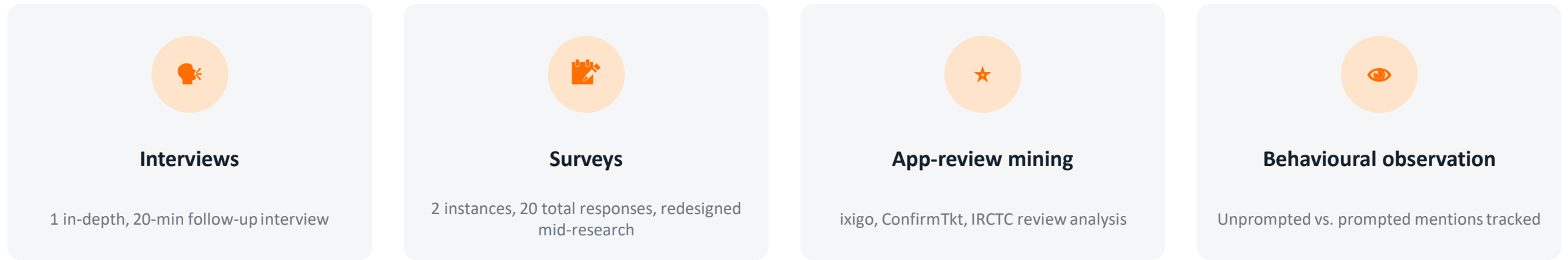
85.55%

Repeat transaction rate, FY26

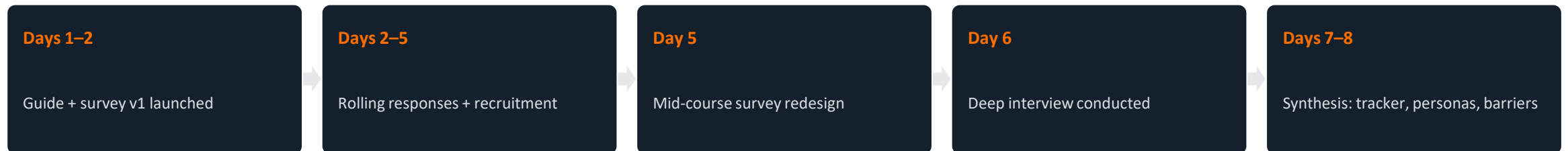
The gap

When a preferred train or class shows unavailable, only 26% of ixigo Trains users complete a resolved booking within 24 hours. The other 74% abandon, wait indefinitely, or resolve outside ixigo entirely — a direct loss of bookings the platform was one step away from capturing.

20 Conversations, Four Methods



Timeline



Mix achieved: predominantly IRCTC-direct users (13 of 20), with a thinner slice of ixigo-direct users (2 of 20) — named honestly as a research limitation, not hidden.

Two Personas, Not One

The research surfaced two genuinely distinct failure modes — a single blended persona would understate the split.

“Reliability Rajiv”

Confirmation-Reliability cluster

AGE / CITY

38, Vadodara

GOAL

A confirmed seat without gambling on tatkal

“For me the problem is confirmation of tickets...not how to find alternatives.”

“Comparing Kavya”

Comparison-Fatigue cluster

AGE / CITY

27, Pune

GOAL

See the best alternatives in one place, fast

“Frustrating when I have to open several trains and compare them one by one.”

“It's Not About Finding Alternatives”

“For me the problem is confirmation of tickets on my desired date and class...and not how to find alternatives.”

— Chirag, in-depth follow-up interview

The IRCTC tatkal booking site reportedly hangs for 15–20 minutes at the exact moment the window opens — the failure isn't discovery, it's confirmation itself.

~40%

of surveyed users hit this failure mode

“Seats Are Getting Booked While I’m Checking”

“Frustrating when I have to open several trains and compare them one by one, especially when seats are getting booked while I’m checking.”

— R11, survey open-text response

The single most independently-corroborated finding in the research — 6+ respondents described this same frustration, unprompted, in their own words.

~60%

of surveyed users hit this failure mode

The Travel-Resolution Funnel



Honest caveat: built from 20 self-reported survey responses and 1 deep interview, not real ixigo funnel analytics — a working hypothesis, not a measured fact.

One Barrier, Two Manifestations

The inability to quickly and confidently secure a confirmed seat once the preferred option fails

~40%

Confirmation-path failure

Shows up upstream — tatkal system overload, or no digital recourse for a post-booking mistake

~60%

Manual comparison effort

Shows up downstream — tedious comparison across trains, classes, and dates under time pressure

Connecting the Barrier to the Target

26%

Today's resolved-
booking rate

➔ 42%

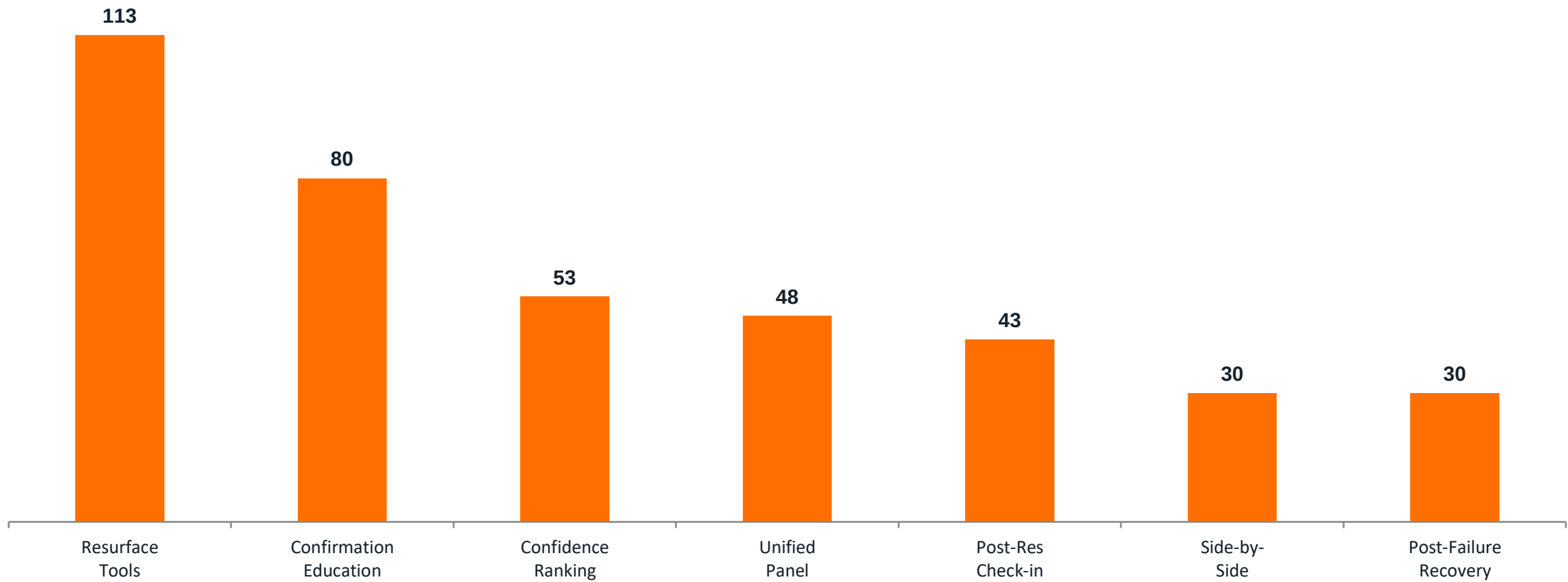
Target, within
6 months

Since confirmation-path failure and comparison effort are close in size (40/60), a single-manifestation fix structurally caps out — targeting both is what unlocks the full 16-point move.

Why both matter

- A comparison-only fix leaves ~40% of the affected population structurally unaddressed
- A confirmation-only fix (fixing IRCTC's own infrastructure) is outside ixigo's control entirely
- The trust barrier within confirmation-failure IS addressable — it's a perception problem, not an infrastructure one

15 Ideas, Ranked by RICE



Top 2 are the only pair that leads on RICE AND deliberately serves one solution per barrier manifestation.

Two Features, One Per Barrier

SOLUTION 1 · RICE 113.3

Resurface Existing Alternatives

The moment a preferred train/class is unavailable, automatically surface ixigo's existing Alternate Travel Plan and AI Seat Finder — ranked, confidence-labeled, with zero new prediction backend needed.

Targets: Comparison-Fatigue (~60%)

SOLUTION 2 · RICE 80.0

Confirmation-Odds Explainer

A lightweight, optional “why am I seeing this?” tap-to-expand explainer — targets the trust barrier directly (“IRCTC owns it, what can ixigo add”) without a forced tutorial.

Targets: Confirmation-Reliability (~40%)

Search to Resolution

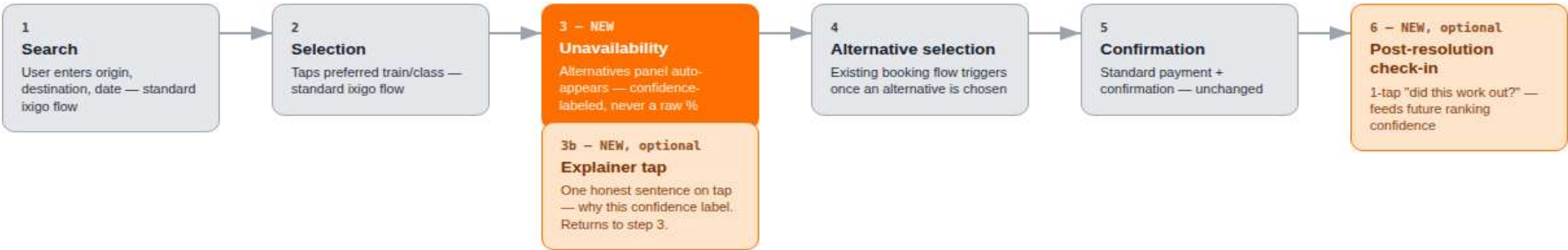
Existing ixigo screens stay untouched — the new surface is contained entirely to the unavailability moment.

User Journey Map — Search to Resolution

Existing ixigo screens stay untouched; the new surface is contained entirely to the unavailability moment

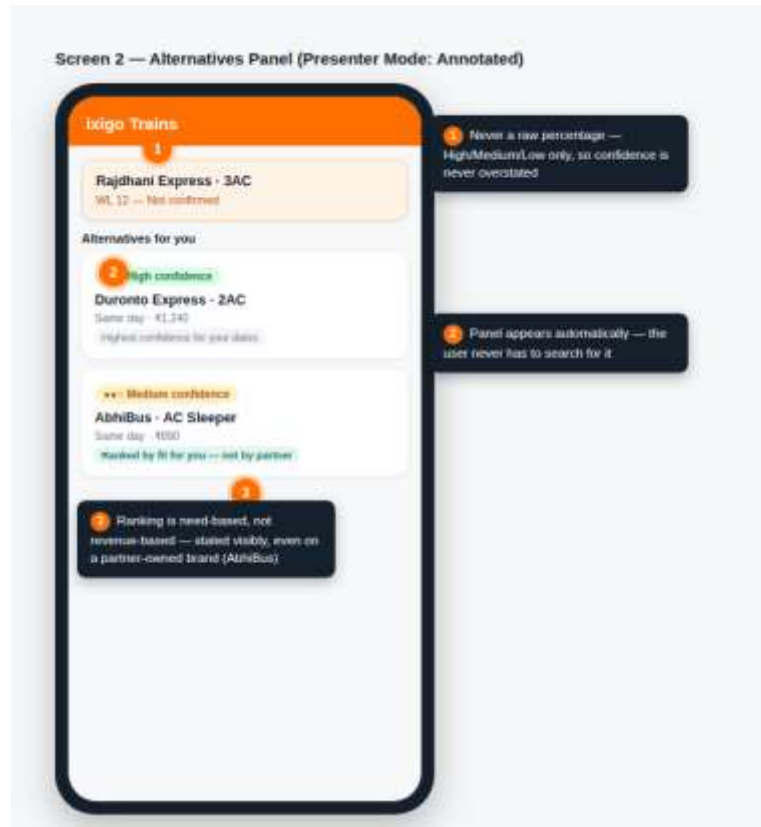
☐ Existing screen (unchanged) ☒ New — core feature ☐ New — optional

STEPS



Honesty, Designed In

The Alternatives panel, in Presenter Mode — the same annotations built into the live prototype for this walkthrough.

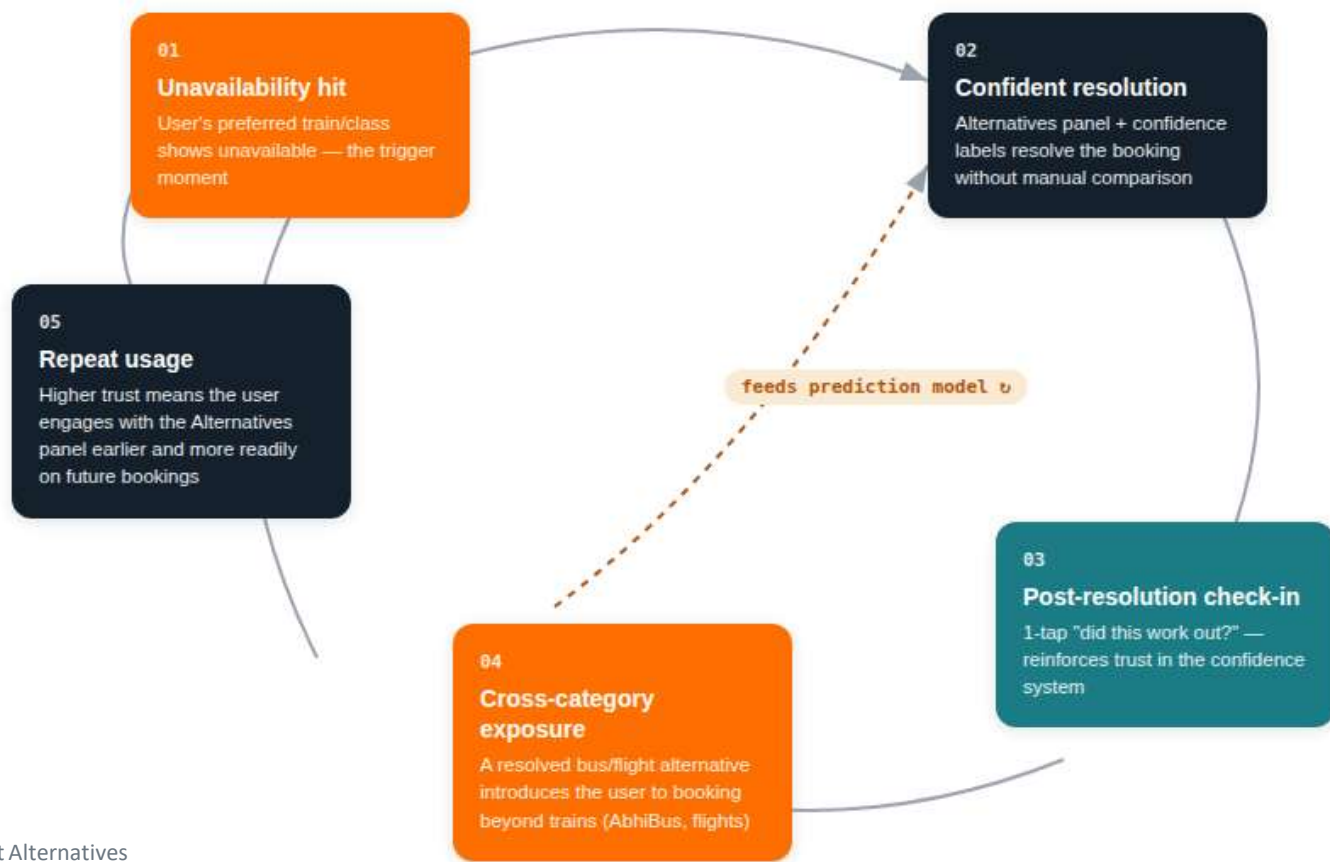


Live, interactive prototype: <https://ixigo-confident-alternatives.lovable.app/>

From One Resolution to Repeat Usage

Growth / Behavior Loop — Resolution to Repeat Usage

A confident resolution reinforces trust, which drives both repeat usage and cross-category booking



Modeled Across Trains, Buses & Flights

Built from ixigo's own stated FY26 figures — not a train-only estimate.

Trains

~4.0M incremental bookings/yr

~₹19.6 crore

Buses + Flights

~1.0M incremental bookings/yr

~₹19.2 crore

Total, all modes

~5.0M incremental bookings/yr

~₹38.8 cr

[ASSUMPTION]

~30% of train bookings encounter unavailability; ~20% of resolutions go cross-modal, grounded in 5 of 20 respondents who mentioned switching to bus/flight. Both flagged explicitly, not asserted as fact.

One North Star, Three Guardrails

NORTH STAR

Resolved Travel Booking Rate — 26% → 42%

Poor Recommendations

Cancellation rate on suggested alternatives;
AbhiBus top-rank share audited against baseline

Overstated Confidence

Calibration accuracy per label, audited against real
outcomes — not asserted once and forgotten

Post-Booking Regret

Check-in negative-response rate; cancellations
among dissatisfied users specifically

What Could Still Go Wrong



Confidence-label miscalibration

Especially on lower-volume routes with thin data — mitigated by launching high-volume routes first



Partner-ranking fairness erodes over time

Commercial pressure could bias toward AbhiBus — mitigated by a visible UI commitment and an audit metric



Research sample skews toward IRCTC-direct users

Only 2 of 20 respondents use ixigo directly — findings treated as directional, not measured fact



Tatkal infrastructure failure is outside ixigo's control

This v1 fixes trust and discovery, not IRCTC's own system — named honestly, not hidden

Summary

2

features, one per barrier manifestation

₹38.8 cr

modeled incremental annual revenue

26%→42%

resolved-booking target

The thread through all nine steps

- The research forced a harder, more honest problem statement than the first draft — one barrier, two manifestations, not one clean story
- The chosen solutions are deliberately incremental — reusing what ixigo already built, rather than a bold rebuild that outruns the evidence
- Every honesty constraint in the brief (no percentages, no guarantees, no favoring owned inventory) is now visible in the prototype's UI, not just stated in a document